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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1960-1964

Coverage Date: 1899-1963

Place Coverage: Eastern Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): ASSAULT

After careful enquiry I learned from my informants that a person should never insinuate or infer that someone is a witch. No one does, even if he believes that individual is a witch, because no worse accusation can be made or conceived. Even in a very heated argument neither party is supposed to give expression to such a thought. Not only is such an accusation the highest insult but the matter is bound to be taken up and reported to the chief and his court. The only time a person can call another a witch is when two ritual friends (*sahwira*) joke with one another and do not take the matter seriously.

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An argument very easily results in court charges if one of the parties uses offensive language about the private parts of the other's mother. This cannot fail to lead to blows. But even this is not so bad as calling someone a witch unless, of course, there is good reason for the statement.

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When a person is accused of being a witch he may be attacked or injured or he may be made to suffer in a number of ways. In [60](#) the 1899–1930 series

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of cases 77.1 per cent. were not apparently affected by the accusation, whereas in the 1959–1963 series a rather greater number were not attacked (81.1 per cent.). This may be due to the greater appreciation by the African public today of the dangers accompanying any such accusation.

Offenses Against The
Person

750
Sickness

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